StoryCast Research Document

Information architecture, design decisions and accessibility rationale

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1. Project summary

StoryCast is a three-page microsite for audio and video storytelling. It is built with semantic HTML5, Sass compiled to CSS, CSS Grid, Flexbox and a container-queried media card, without frameworks. The goal is simple: a story should be usable by everyone, whether they listen, read, navigate by keyboard or use a screen reader.

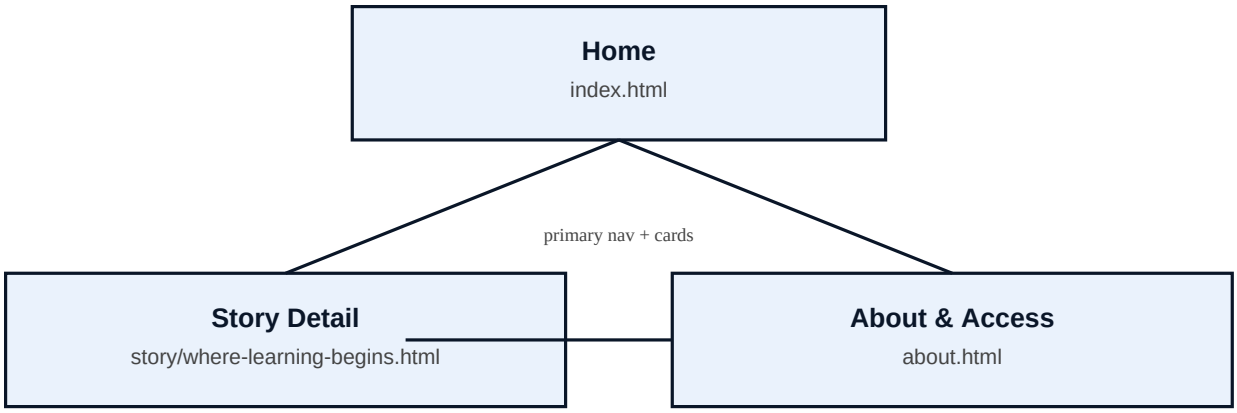
2. Audience and needs

The design started from the people most often left out by media sites.

User group	What they need	How StoryCast responds
Deaf and hard-of-hearing visitors	A text equivalent of every sound	Full inline transcript, downloadable .txt transcript, WebVTT captions on video
Blind and low-vision visitors	Logical structure, labelled media, alt text	Landmarks, one h1 per page, ordered headings, descriptive alt text, labelled players
Keyboard and switch users	Reach everything without a mouse	Skip link, native controls, visible orange focus ring, scrollable transcript is focusable
Mobile and small-screen users	Readable layouts and large tap targets	Fluid grids, single-column stacking, relative units
Users in noisy places or on slow data	Read instead of listen	Transcript below the player; images lazy-loaded below the fold, small compressed media

3. Information architecture

The site is deliberately small: three pages, each with one clear purpose, and every page reachable from every other in one click through the primary navigation.



Page	Purpose	Key content
Home (index.html)	Introduce StoryCast and route visitors to stories	Hero, featured story, list of recent story cards
Story Detail (story/where-learning-begins.html)	Let a visitor experience one story fully	Breadcrumb, audio player, photos, captioned video, transcript, related stories, accessibility summary
About & Access (about.html)	Explain the mission and how access features work	Mission, six accessibility features, about the creator, how to engage

Why this shape. A flat three-page structure keeps navigation predictable, which is itself an accessibility benefit: there are no menus or hidden levels. The Story page puts the media first and the transcript directly beneath it, so the text alternative is never more than a scroll away. Related stories sit in a sidebar so a visitor who finishes a story has a next step.

Navigation. The primary navigation is identical on every page, with `aria-current="page"` marking the active page. A breadcrumb on the Story page shows the path back to Home, and the footer repeats the main links.

4. Design decisions

Colour

A deep navy background with white text and a bright blue accent gives a calm, focused listening environment. Orange is used only for the focus ring and skip link so it is distinctive and never confused with ordinary links.

Role	Hex	Used for
Background	#0a1628	Page background
Surface	#0f2044	Header, footer, cards, players
Border	#1e3a6e	Dividers and card outlines
Accent	#4da6ff	Links, tags, logo highlight
Button	#0b6fd6	Primary button background (white text)
Muted text	#a0b4cc	Secondary text
Focus	#f97316	Focus ring and skip link

Typography

Inter, with a system-ui fallback. It is highly legible at small sizes. Body text is 16 px with a 1.6 line height, headings use a tighter 1.2, and paragraph width is capped (65 to 72 characters) for comfortable reading. The h1 scales fluidly with clamp().

Layout

CSS Grid handles page-level layout (story grid, story page with sidebar, about grid). Flexbox handles components (header, navigation, card bodies, meta rows). A media-card component uses a container query

so it adapts to the space it is given rather than to the viewport.

5. Accessibility rationale (WCAG 2.1 AA)

Contrast ratios were calculated with the WCAG relative-luminance formula for the colour pairs used on the site:

Pair	Ratio	Requirement	Result
White on background (#ffffff / #0a1628)	18.1:1	4.5:1	Pass
Muted text on background (#a0b4cc / #0a1628)	8.5:1	4.5:1	Pass
Muted text on surface (#a0b4cc / #0f2044)	7.6:1	4.5:1	Pass
Muted text on transcript panel (#a0b4cc / #162d5e)	6.3:1	4.5:1	Pass
Accent links on background (#4da6ff / #0a1628)	7.1:1	4.5:1	Pass
White on primary button (#ffffff / #0b6fd6)	4.9:1	4.5:1	Pass
Focus ring on background (#f97316 / #0a1628)	6.5:1	3:1 (non-text)	Pass

- **Text alternatives:** every audio and video item has a transcript or captions; every informative image has descriptive alt text.
- **Structure:** header, nav, main, article, section, aside, figure/figcaption and footer landmarks; one h1 per page.
- **Keyboard:** skip-to-content link, native media controls, :focus-visible outlines, and a focusable scrollable transcript region.
- **ARIA only where needed:** aria-labelledby on sections, aria-label to distinguish the two navigation landmarks, aria-current on the active link.
- **Motion:** the site uses no auto-playing media and no animation beyond short colour transitions.

6. Responsive strategy

The layout is built mobile-first in principle and verified at three ranges: below 480 px (header stacks, buttons stack, single-column cards), 480 to 767 px (tighter spacing and smaller headings) and 768 px and up (two-column featured story and about grid). At 1024 px the Story page becomes a two-column layout with a sidebar. The media card is wrapped in a container-type: inline-size element and switches from a stacked layout to a horizontal image-plus-text layout when its container is wide enough.

7. Process, trade-offs and limitations

- The site has one detail page by design, because the brief asks for a single story page. The Home page cards link to its two sections (Isunzu Yacu and Bigogwe), and one card is marked coming soon.
- The story audio is the author's own recording, and the transcript is written to match it. Photos and videos were taken by the author during the visits.

- Accessibility was checked by manual keyboard testing, contrast calculation and heading-order review. A fuller audit with a screen reader and an automated checker (such as WAVE or Lighthouse) is recommended before launch.

8. Design files

Sitemap, wireframes and high-fidelity mockups (Figma): **[PASTE FIGMA SHARE LINK HERE]**

Code repository: **https://github.com/divine150-coder/storycast**